Massachusetts Voters Will Decide Whether Towns Must Allow Smaller Homes

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-14 5 min read

Massachusetts is one of the most expensive states in the country for housing. Now voters there will decide on a **ballot measure** that aims to make it easier to build smaller, cheaper homes.

Many cities and towns across the U.S. have rules called **minimum lot sizes**. These rules say a single-family house must sit on a piece of land of a certain size. In Massachusetts, most such rules require at least an **acre**, which is about 40,000 square feet. That is nearly the size of a football field without the end zones.

The **ballot measure** would require towns to allow homes on lots as small as 5,000 square feet, about the size of a basketball court. It would not apply to Boston, which has its own rules. If it passes, Massachusetts would join a growing number of states that have made similar changes.

Supporters say big lot rules mean fewer homes get built, and the ones that are built tend to be large and expensive. Housing **economist** Andrew Mikula, who is leading the push, said many older homes on small lots would be illegal to build today. Supporters also say high prices are pushing young workers out of the state. Polling suggests broad support for the measure.

Jamie Sharken, a 34-year-old renter, told NPR she shares a house with three other people and doubts she can afford to buy a home. She supports the idea.

Critics do not like the state taking control away from local towns. They also question whether the homes will really be **affordable**. A Lexington official showed NPR an old house on a small lot that had been expanded and was listed for nearly $1.3 million.

Word Treasure

ballot measure -- A question that voters answer directly in an election to decide whether a rule becomes law.

minimum lot sizes -- Rules that say how big a piece of land must be before a house can be built on it.

acre -- A unit for measuring land; one acre is a little smaller than a football field.

economist -- A person who studies how money, jobs and resources are used.

affordable -- Cheap enough that people can pay for it.

Background you need

Zoning rules are local laws that decide what can be built on each piece of land in a city or town, such as houses, stores or apartments.

Minimum lot size rules set how much land a single-family house needs, so larger requirements mean fewer, bigger homes fit in an area.

When there are not enough homes for everyone who wants one, prices and rents tend to rise.

In some states, voters can decide a rule directly through a ballot measure instead of waiting for lawmakers to pass it.

Break it down

LEAD: Massachusetts voters will decide on a measure to allow smaller, cheaper homes
KEY EVENT: A ballot measure on minimum lot sizes
+- WHAT: Towns must allow homes on lots as small as 5,000 square feet
+- WHERE: Massachusetts, except Boston
BACKGROUND: Most current rules require at least an acre per single-family home
SUPPORTERS: Andrew Mikula says many older small-lot homes would be illegal to build today; polling suggests broad support
PERSONAL VIEW: Renter Jamie Sharken doubts she can afford a home and supports the idea
CRITICS: Worry about losing local control and question whether homes will be affordable
OPEN QUESTION: Will smaller lots really lead to cheaper homes?

Why it matters

Rules about land size shape how many homes get built and who can afford to live in a community, an issue many states are now facing.

Test what you remember

1. What would the ballot measure require towns to allow?

- (A) No new homes at all
- (B) Taller office buildings
- (C) Homes on lots as small as 5,000 square feet
- (D) Only apartments

2. How much land do most single-family zoning rules in Massachusetts require?

- (A) About 500 square feet
- (B) Half a mile
- (C) At least an acre
- (D) Exactly 5,000 square feet

3. Which city would the measure NOT apply to?

- (A) Every town
- (B) Boston
- (C) North Braintree
- (D) Lexington

4. Who is leading the push for the measure?

- (A) A Lexington official
- (B) Jamie Sharken
- (C) Housing economist Andrew Mikula
- (D) The governor

5. What is one worry critics have?

- (A) Homes would be too small to live in
- (B) The state would take control away from local towns
- (C) Boston would grow too fast
- (D) Basketball courts would disappear

6. About how much was the expanded old house on a small lot listed for?

- (A) $130,000
- (B) $40,000
- (C) $5,000
- (D) Nearly $1.3 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Supporters, including Andrew Mikula: Say large lot rules mean fewer, more expensive homes and push young workers out of the state.

2. Jamie Sharken, renter: Shares a house with three others, doubts she can afford to buy, and supports the measure.

3. Critics, including a Lexington official: Oppose the state taking control from towns and question whether the homes will be affordable.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):